



# EMPLOYEE VS EMPLOYER

## EMPLOYER NAYS

- ▶ Working for a competitor
- ▶ Information security, especially leak of sensitive data, loss of confidentiality
- ▶ Violation of contracts IT services firms have with clients
- ▶ Use of organisation resources, such as licensed software, for side gigs
- ▶ Drop in employee productivity and performance
- ▶ Employee disengagement and retention amid high attrition

## EMPLOYEE YAYS

- ▶ **Types of gigs:** Projects/assignments similar to their main job to use their current knowledge and experience or pursue passion projects
- ▶ **Motives:** To earn extra money and, sometimes, to gain additional skills and experience
- ▶ **Where do they find the side jobs?** Freelancing websites such as Upwork post software-related gigs such as web design, development and game design offering even \$10,000 a month. Top employers such as Microsoft, Airbnb, GoDaddy and Nasdaq list gigs on these sites. Moonlighters also tap into their network of friends, colleagues and former colleagues for gigs

Harpreet Singh Saluja, President of Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES), even points out that some industry leaders were themselves moonlighters at one point. “Flipkart was founded by Sachin Bansal and Binny Bansal while they were working for Amazon. Freshdesk [now Freshworks] was founded by Girish Mathrubootham while he was working for Zoho Corp.” Countless start-ups today were born while their founders were employed full-time at another firm and some of their first hires also come from their previous employer, agree experts. Some say it would have been difficult for the likes of Infosys to have taken shape but for moonlighting. Infosys Founder N.R. Narayana Murthy refused to respond to *BT*’s email queries, saying he has retired.

Besides, Saluja points out that there are no IT jobs where an employee can work for both, say, Wipro and its direct competitor. “If people are moonlighting, they are probably freelancing as gig workers, for their friends, or family, or for small start-ups. Can any of these places be

considered as direct competitors of Wipro?” he asks of the firm’s claim of firing 300 employees found moonlighting with their competitors.

The other side of this coin is the ‘where’. You want to moonlight, sure, but where do you find the gigs? It’s far easier to moonlight today because of dedicated freelancing platforms such as Upwork, Freelancer and Toptal, which are awash with gigs, supposedly posted even by leading firms such as Microsoft, Airbnb, GoDaddy and Nasdaq. Web design and development for \$75 per hour, app development for a flat \$7,000, and a three-month assignment as Senior Network Gameplay Engineer for \$9,000, are among the more than 160,000 gigs up for grabs on Upwork alone. Physical organisations are also ‘hiring’ engineers for testing, integration, training, and even for interviewing other candidates.

These geography-agnostic platforms with short but well-paying assignments and the fact that technology work itself has been broken up into small bits that can